1. How History and Culture have Shaped China’s World View

India and China are civilizational states with long histories and rich cultures that have crystallized through both internal evolution and external stimulation. They have been ruled by empires both native and foreign; they have gone through phases of fragmentation, even dissolution; and of integration and centralization. There has been an ebb and flow in the spaces controlled by political centres in both countries, but in their telling of their own histories, the more centralized and expansive phases are highlighted and projected as the norm, while the equally persistent periods of fragmentation are interpreted as aberrations. Both countries articulated a spatial and ideal notion of their respective geographies and how this related to their cosmological perspectives.

During the ancient Shang dynasty (1600–1048 BCE), there were said to be nine regions of China, stretching to the sea on the east, to the ‘moving sands’ of the desert on the west, and to the ‘utmost limits of the north and south’. Later, during the Warring States and early Han period (453–c. 200 BCE), more elaborate conceptions emerged. China was described as a central rectangle surrounded on each side by the sea, beyond which lay a great wilderness.

In 250 BCE , Chinese cosmology described the world as composed of nine continents. The nine regions of China mentioned in the Shang chronicles belonged to one of these nine continents but constituted just one-ninth of the area of the continent. Each of these continents was surrounded by an expanse of water, and a vast ocean surrounded all the nine continents.

There are parallels with ancient Indian cosmology and India’s location as a sacred geography within it. In ancient Indian cosmology, there are said to be seven continents radiating outwards from the centre, each surrounded by oceans. These are likened to the petals of a lotus ranged in rows, similarly